

THE PHILIPPINES

LOCATED ON THE “RING OF FIRE” – the arc of volcanoes running through maritime Southeast Asia – and in the path of violent tropical storms, the Philippines suffers from earthquakes and volcanic eruptions. The country consists of 7,107 islands, of which only about 1,000 are inhabited. Most of the people live on the northern island of Luzon, which contains the capital, Manila. For almost 400 years the Philippines was governed by Spain; in fact the country is named after the Spanish king Philip II. In 1898 control passed to the US, then in 1946 the Philippines became an independent nation. Most Filipinos are of Malay origin, but there are some Chinese immigrants and mixed-blood *mestizos*.



MANILA

Much of the capital city of the Philippines lies below sea level, and it suffers from floods during the rainy summer season. The Spanish captured Manila in 1571, fortifying its walls and making it the center of their Asian empire. Over the centuries, Manila has been an important trading port, with merchants arriving from as far afield as Arabia, India, and Japan. Today, it is a bustling modern city with more than 10 million inhabitants.



SMOKY MOUNTAIN

On the edge of Manila lies a vast mountain. Unlike other mountains, this one is not made of rock, but of garbage. Every day the garbage trucks of Manila arrive there to dump their loads of household waste. Many people, some of them children as young as four, live on the mountain, searching the refuse daily for bottles, cans, plastics, and cardboard that they can sell for recycling.

AMAZING JEEPS

At the end of World War II, the US Army left thousands of unwanted jeeps in the Philippines. Local people soon converted these for their own use, decorating them in amazing colors and patterns. The jeep can cope with the rugged conditions and poor roads of the countryside and is now one of the main forms of transportation in the Philippines.

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Capital city: Manila

Area: 115,830 sq miles (300,000 sq km)

Population: 80,000,000

Official languages: Filipino and English

Major religions: Christian 92%, Muslim 5%, other 3%

Government: Multiparty democracy

Currency: Philippine peso

Adult literacy rate: 93%

Life expectancy: 70 years

People per doctor: 2,599

Televisions: 108 per 1,000 people



April 2, 1991: the growth of a lava dome shows that Mt. Pinatubo is about to erupt.



June 14, 1991: the mountain begins to spew deadly clouds of gas and ash.



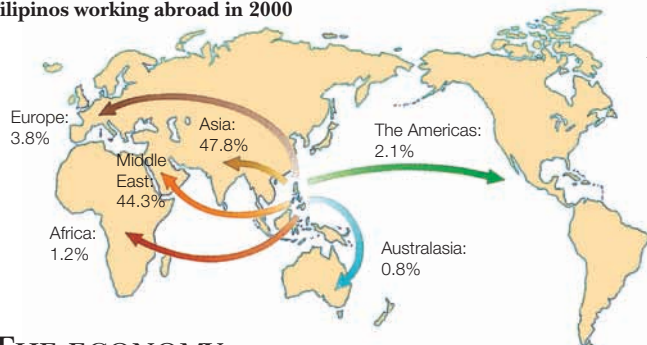
June 15, 1991: a huge blast blows out the mountainside, and molten lava floods down the slopes.



MOUNT PINATUBO

In June 1991, Mount Pinatubo, a volcano north of Manila on the island of Luzon, burst into life. For 10 days, it spewed out volcanic ash and rocks in one of the biggest volcanic eruptions ever recorded. The landscape was soon covered with a layer of debris some 23 ft (7 m) deep. Heavy rainfall turned much of this to sludge, blocking rivers, and filling up valleys. The local Aeta tribespeople lost their land and houses overnight.

Filipinos working abroad in 2000



About 2% of the workforce are working abroad at any one time, sending money home to support their families. Each year, more than US\$1 billion flows into the country's economy in this way.

THE ECONOMY

Once one of the richer nations in Asia, in the last few decades the Philippines has fallen behind its economically powerful neighbors. Half the population lives in poverty, and many Filipinos can only support their families by working abroad. The Philippines is rich in natural resources, with reserves of gold, copper, and chrome. The main export crops are tobacco, sugar, and a wide range of tropical fruits.

